

## Module 13 · B1 · Independent user

# The conditional: politeness, advice and hypotheses

Je voudrais, tu devrais, si j'avais... — the mood of requests, suggestions and imagined situations.

## ● YOU'LL BE ABLE TO

- ✓ Form the conditional of any verb using the futur stems
- ✓ Make polite requests and give advice
- ✓ Use si + imparfait → conditionnel for hypotheses
- ✓ Distinguish the three si-clause patterns

|                       | aimer                           | être (ser-)               | pouvoir (pourr-)         |
|-----------------------|---------------------------------|---------------------------|--------------------------|
| <b>je</b>             | aimerais<br>I would like / love | serais<br>I would be      | pourrais<br>I could      |
| <b>tu</b>             | aimerais<br>you would like      | serais<br>you would be    | pourrais<br>you could    |
| <b>il / elle / on</b> | aimerait<br>he would like       | serait<br>he would be     | pourrait<br>he could     |
| <b>nous</b>           | aimerions<br>we would like      | serions<br>we would be    | pourrions<br>we could    |
| <b>vous</b>           | aimeriez<br>you would like      | seriez<br>you would be    | pourriez<br>you could    |
| <b>ils / elles</b>    | aimeraient<br>they would like   | seraient<br>they would be | pourraient<br>they could |

| Type                             | si + ...                                        | main clause                                               | Example                                                                                     |
|----------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Real / likely</b>             | présent<br>present tense                        | présent, futur or impératif<br>present, future or command | Si tu as le temps, viens me voir.<br>If you have time, come and see me.                     |
| <b>Hypothetical (now/future)</b> | imparfait<br>imperfect (was doing / used to do) | conditionnel présent<br>present conditional (would do)    | Si j'avais plus de temps, je ferais du bénévolat.<br>If I had more time, I would volunteer. |
| <b>Unreal past (regret)</b>      | plus-que-parfait<br>pluperfect (had done)       | conditionnel passé<br>past conditional (would have done)  | Si j'avais su, je serais venu plus tôt.<br>If I had known, I would have come earlier.       |

## ● KEY PHRASES

**Tu devrais t'inscrire à un cours du soir.**  
You should sign up for an evening class.

**À ta place, je parlerais directement au propriétaire.**  
If I were you, I'd speak directly to the landlord.

**On pourrait partager les frais de transport.**  
We could share the transport costs.

**Bonjour, je voudrais des renseignements sur vos cours du soir.**  
Hello, I'd like some information about your evening classes.

**Pourriez-vous me dire s'il reste des places ?**  
Could you tell me if there are any spots left?

**Si j'avais plus de temps, je ferais du bénévolat.**  
If I had more time, I'd volunteer.

**À mon avis, il faudrait investir davantage dans les transports en commun.**  
In my view, we should invest more in public transit.

**Si les loyers étaient moins chers, les familles resteraient en ville.**  
If rents were cheaper, families would stay in the city.

**Tu devrais en parler à ton gestionnaire.**  
You should talk to your manager about it.

## ● AVOID THESE MISTAKES

~~X Si j'aurais le temps, je viendrais.~~  
Never the conditional after si.

✓ Si j'avais le temps, je viendrais.

~~X Si j'ai plus d'argent, j'achèterais une maison.~~  
Conditionnel in the main clause ↔ imparfait after si.

✓ Si j'avais plus d'argent, j'achèterais une maison.

~~X Je veux un café. (to a server)~~  
The conditional is the polite form for requests.

✓ Je voudrais un café.

~~X Tu dois voir un médecin. (as friendly advice)~~  
devoir in the present is an obligation; devrais is advice.

✓ Tu devrais voir un médecin.

~~X Je pourrais, je voudrais~~  
Same irregular stems as the futur.

✓ je pourrais, je voudrais

~~X j'aimerai (meaning "I would like")~~  
-ai is futur; -ais is conditional. It matters in writing.

✓ j'aimerais

## ● MUST-KNOW WORDS

**à ta / votre place** if I were you

**investir** to invest

**il faudrait** we/one should

**le bénévolat** volunteering

**ça vaudrait la peine** it would be worth it

**selon** according to

**d'avantage** more

**éventuellement** possibly (false friend: not "eventually")

**réduire** to reduce

**un souhait** a wish

**augmenter** to increase

**envisager** to consider

## ● TIP

Either clause can come first: **Je ferais du bénévolat si j'avais plus de temps.** The tenses stay attached to their clauses.